BEFORE YOU SAY YES · NEW EDITION

Leader's Guide

For small-group leaders, pastors, mentors and parents walking with single Christians through the 21 lessons

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1. About this guide

Before You Say Yes is a course for single Christians who are dating, or about to. It is based on the book of the same name and follows it chapter by chapter. It is not a premarital course: when a relationship reaches the threshold of engagement, the closing lesson says so, and *Talk Before You Marry* is the course for what comes next.

The course has 21 illustrated, narrated lessons of about 18 to 21 minutes each, in five parts and a closing lesson. Each lesson opens with a passage of Scripture, explains it in its setting, often with one Hebrew or Greek word, and then teaches, with a small step to take and a quiet prayer at the end.

Below each lesson the learner finds:

- a short safety note directly under the player, where the lesson needs one, with a link to **Finding Help Where You Live**;
- **One step now**, a single small action, with writing always optional and private;
- the full **Reflection**, one of the book's tools, done alone first;
- **Scripture to sit with**, **Look back** and **Talk about it** questions for groups or a friend;
- **Go deeper**, which points to the matching chapter of the book.

This guide is for anyone who walks alongside learners: a small-group leader, a pastor, a mentor, a friend, or a parent of a young adult. You do not need to be an expert. You do need to be safe, honest and patient, and to know where to send someone who needs more help than you can give.

Each lesson section gives you the lesson's purpose, the passage and its background, a note on the original word, the cautions the book itself gives, a **Don't miss this** box, the discussion questions, and a short note for parents and mentors.

Three things this course never does

- It never asks anyone to tell a group about their own relationship, past or fears.
- It never treats a worksheet, a feeling or a church's approval as a verdict on whether someone should marry.
- Its completion record never says that a learner is "ready", "prepared" or "certified" for engagement or marriage.

2. Ways to use the course

Setting	How it works	Notes
On your own, with a mentor	The learner watches each lesson and does the Reflection alone. You meet every week or two to talk about the teaching.	The learner decides what to share. Use the Talk about it questions and the parents and mentors notes.
Small group	Watch together, or before the meeting, then discuss the Talk about it questions. See the session plan in section 5.	Discuss principles, never anyone's own relationship. Each person does the Reflections privately at home.
Church programme for single adults	Run the parts as terms: Parts 1–2 (7 lessons), Part 3 (5), Parts 4–5 and the closing lesson (9).	Agree a safeguarding lead before you begin, and complete Appendix B.
Parents of young adults	Watch the lessons yourself, especially Lessons 6, 10, 14 and 21, so you understand what your son or daughter is learning.	See section 7. Do not use the course to supervise an adult child's relationship.

Pace. One lesson a week is ideal. Two lessons in one meeting can work in Parts 1 and 2, but give Lessons 6, 9, 10, 12, 19 and 20 a meeting of their own: they carry more weight and more safety material.

Couples. A dating couple may take the course together, but each person watches, reflects and decides for themselves. Where a Reflection is compared, the book says which parts, and only where both can speak freely and safely. A leader should never ask a couple to compare answers in front of others.

Age. The course is written for adults. If anyone under eighteen takes part, your church's safeguarding policy applies in full, including to any disclosure (see section 4).

3. Leading safely

Most people who take this course are in ordinary situations: hopeful, unsure, or recovering from an ending. The book assumes two people of goodwill who can speak freely. For some learners that is not true, and a group can be where they first realise it. These ground rules protect everyone.

- **Talk about principles, never about persons.** Every Talk about it question is about the teaching. Do not ask anyone to describe their own relationship, family, finances, sexual history or past. If someone chooses to share, thank them briefly and bring the discussion back to the principle.
- **Reflections stay private.** Nobody shares a worksheet in a group, and nobody is asked what they wrote. Several Reflections (Lessons 6, 10 and 19, and Questions Before Engagement) are unsaved worksheets on the website for exactly this reason.
- **No one diagnoses anyone else's relationship.** Not you, and not the group. A group is not an audience and it is not a court.
- **Know where help is before you need it.** Complete Appendix B before the first meeting; this is required, not optional. Show the group the Finding Help Where You Live page and the **Leave this page** button, which takes the screen to a weather page at once.
- **Safety before process.** If there may be abuse, coercion, stalking or forced marriage, ordinary advice (talk it through, slow down, end it kindly, meet the family) can make things more dangerous. Do not suggest couples counselling, family mediation or a joint conversation as a first response. Follow section 4.
- **Do not confront, investigate or contact.** Never approach the other person, their family or their church leaders on a learner's behalf, and never search into anyone's past.
- **Declare your interests.** If you know the person someone is dating, are related to them, or have a ministry stake in the outcome, say so and step back from advising.
- **Explain the limits of confidentiality.** At the start, ask the group to respect one another's privacy and not repeat personal information outside the group. Explain that you have safeguarding responsibilities and may have legal duties, and that because this is a group, absolute confidentiality cannot be guaranteed. Use your church's own wording.
- **Spiritual language must never pressure.** "God told me", "submit", "forgive" and "God's timing" are good words that can be misused. If anyone, including a leader, uses them to push a decision, see Lessons 6 and 13 and offer independent help.

4. If someone tells you they are afraid

If a learner tells you they are afraid of the person they are dating, that they have been threatened, hurt, sexually pressured, followed, tracked, isolated or controlled through money, or that their family is forcing a marriage, respond like this:

1. **Listen and believe.** Thank them for telling you. Say that it is not their fault and that they were right to speak.
2. **Check immediate safety.** If anyone is in immediate danger, contact the emergency service where you are.

3. **Ask how it is safe to contact them.** Before arranging any follow-up, ask whether it is safe to telephone, message or email them. A message or call may be seen by someone who monitors their phone or accounts. If no method is safe, agree to speak in person at the next meeting, if attending that meeting is safe.
4. **Do not investigate, confront or mediate.** Do not contact the other person or the family, and do not arrange a meeting between them.
5. **Point to specialist help.** Give them the details in Appendix B, or the Finding Help Where You Live page, and suggest using a device the other person cannot access.
6. **Share information only where necessary.** Share what you have been told only where it is necessary for safety, or required by law or your safeguarding policy, and only with appropriate people. Normally tell the person who needs to know and why, unless doing so would increase the danger or interfere with a legal safeguarding duty. Explain the limits of confidentiality clearly, and do not promise secrecy you cannot keep.
7. **Adults and children are different.** An adult with capacity makes their own decisions: do not contact their family members, partner or church leaders simply because a disclosure has been made. Where a child may be at risk, or the person is under eighteen, follow your church's child-safeguarding procedure and tell your safeguarding lead. Child-protection and mandatory-reporting duties vary by country; know the ones that apply where you are.
8. **Keep a brief factual note** if your church's policy asks for one, stored securely.
9. **Stay alongside them.** Ask what would help next time you meet. Do not press them to act faster than is safe for them.

If someone speaks of hopelessness or not wanting to live

- Do not treat it as a discussion question, and do not move on.
- Speak with them privately that day. Ask directly and calmly whether they are having thoughts of suicide, whether they intend to act on them now, and whether they have access to the means. Asking does not put the idea in someone's mind.
- If there is immediate intent or danger, contact the emergency service and stay with them. Otherwise help them reach a crisis line or their doctor (Appendix B) that day, and tell your safeguarding lead.
- You are not expected to assess or manage suicide risk alone. Seek urgent professional help whenever you are unsure.

Threats of self-harm used to keep someone in a relationship. The book is clear (Lessons 6 and 19): such a threat is handed to people who can carry it, such as emergency services or a crisis line. It is not a reason to resume or continue a relationship.

5. A group session

Full session (75 minutes). Adjust it to your group.

Time	What happens
5 min	Welcome. At the first meeting, read the group agreement (Appendix A) together.
5 min	**Look back.** One question from the previous lesson, as on the lesson page. It is not a test.
20 min	**Watch the lesson** together on a screen with the captions on, or ask everyone to watch it beforehand.
5 min	**Read the passage aloud** in its setting (the longer reading is in this guide under Scripture and background).
25 min	**Talk about it.** Use the three questions on the lesson page and the extra question from the passage in this guide. Keep to principles.
5 min	**One step now**, in silence. Writing is optional and private.
10 min	Pray, using the lesson's closing prayer or your own words. Remind the group where help is.

Shorter session (50 minutes), for groups that watch the lesson beforehand:

Time	What happens
5 min	Welcome (and, at the first meeting, the group agreement).
5 min	**Read the passage aloud** in its setting.
25 min	**Talk about it.** Choose the questions that suit your group.
5 min	**One step now**, in private reflection.
10 min	Pray, and remind the group where help is.

You do not need to cover every question. Two questions discussed thoughtfully are better than four rushed.

Before you lead. Watch the lesson, read the passage in your own Bible, and read the matching chapter of the book. Read this guide's page for the lesson, especially the cautions and **Don't miss this**.

After you lead. If anyone seemed troubled, find a private moment to ask how they are. Do not raise what they said in front of others.

6. Handling Scripture and original words

The course follows the book's habits with Scripture, and leaders are asked to keep them:

- **Passage first, in its setting.** Each lesson begins with the text and who it was written to.
- **Say when you are applying a passage beyond its first meaning.** Many passages used in the course were not written about dating (for example Hebrews 5:14, Philippians 1:9–10, Matthew 5:37, Ephesians 4:2, Luke 14:28). The lessons say so, and you should too: learners should be able to tell what God has said from what we think follows from it.
- **Narratives are not blueprints.** Absalom, Rebekah, Ruth, Rehoboam, Gideon, Paul and Barnabas teach by example; they are not methods for choosing a spouse.
- **Original words are a help, not a key.** The word cards give a word's meaning in its setting. Do not make a word carry more than the passage allows, and present conclusions as conclusions.
- **Where Christians differ**, for example on how God speaks today or on remarriage after divorce, present the differences fairly and point people to their own church's teaching and pastor.

Scripture quotations in the course are from the ESV. Transliterations follow the course's word cards.

7. For parents and mentors

The book is written for single Christians and "for the people who walk with them: parents, mentors, pastors, friends". If you are walking with a young adult, your place is real and valuable. It is also different from a leader's or a counsellor's.

For parents of young adults

- **Your adult child makes the decision.** A family blessing, freely given, is a real gift. But no family member can give or withhold an adult's consent to marriage (Lesson 10). The course will say this plainly; it is better that they hear you say it too.
- **Honour is not obedience.** Adult children owe their parents honour and care, but not unlimited access, financial compliance, or remaining exposed to harm.
- **Be a voice, not a vote.** Say what you have observed, specifically and once, then keep the door open (Lesson 14). Ultimatums usually push people towards the person you are worried about.

- **Separate conscience from preference.** Some expectations come from faith and conscience; others come from culture, status or what relatives will say. Lesson 10's four groups (required by conscience, gladly honoured, negotiable, would not accept) are as useful for parents as for learners.
- **Watch what you joke about.** Comments about age, grandchildren or "being left on the shelf" add to a fear many single adults already carry (Lesson 20).
- **Make home a safe place to say "I'm afraid".** If your young adult is in danger, the most helpful thing you can do is help them reach specialist help, not confront the other person yourself.

For mentors and pastors

- **Know your limits.** Pastoral office does not bring expertise in trauma, abuse, addiction, mental health, finance or legal risk (Lesson 14). Refer without hesitation.
- **Keep confidences, and say when you cannot.** If you know something confidential about the other person, you may not be free to share it. Do not let your silence be heard as endorsement.
- **Let the learner do the reflecting.** Ask what they noticed and what they are deciding. Do not ask to see their worksheets.
- **Speak for good signs too.** "I have never seen you this settled" is counsel as well (Lesson 14).
- **Receive every no as final**, and never present someone's no as disobedience to God (Lessons 13 and 16).

Each lesson section below ends with a short note **For parents and mentors**.

8. The lessons, one by one

*Each section follows the same pattern: the lesson at a glance, its purpose, the Scripture and background, the original word, the book's cautions, **Don't miss this**, the discussion questions, and a note for parents and mentors.*

PART 1 · BEFORE YOU START DATING

Part 1 looks inward before it looks outward: why I want a relationship, what "equally yoked" means, and who I am.

LESSON 1

Why Do You Want a Relationship?

What is driving my desire for a relationship?

At a glance	
Passage	Genesis 2:18–24
Also read	Philippians 4:11–12 · 1 Corinthians 7:7–9, 32–35 · Psalm 68:6 · Psalm 139:23–24
The learner will see	Why the desire for a relationship is not a spiritual weakness (Genesis 2:18–24) Seven motives that can shape dating, and what each one does to your judgement Why contentment is the presence of trust, not the absence of desire (Philippians 4:11) How to begin wherever you are right now: single, dating, or after an ending
Reflection	Tool 1, Relationship Readiness Reflection (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If loneliness has turned into hopelessness or thoughts of not wanting to live, please speak with someone you trust today.

Purpose

To show that the desire for companionship is good, given before the fall, and to help learners see the mixture of motives that shapes their dating, so that contentment, not desperation, is the place they choose from.

Scripture and background

Genesis 1 repeats "good" and "very good"; the first "not good" (2:18) comes before sin enters the world. The naming of the animals shows that no corresponding partner had yet been found. Marriage is one good expression of being made for relationship, yet Jesus and Paul were unmarried.

The original word

עֵזֶר כְּנֶגְדּוֹ (*ʿēzer kenegdô*) — "a helper fit for him" (Genesis 2:18). ʿēzer means help, one who helps, and is used of God himself (Psalm 33:20). kenegdô means corresponding to him. That the woman is not made lesser is a fair conclusion from how Scripture uses the word; teach it as a conclusion, not as the word's definition.

The book's cautions

The book is careful to say that Genesis 2 leads to marriage without teaching that every person must marry. Some in the group may be single after loss, divorce or many years of waiting: speak of contentment without implying that their longing is a failure.

Don't miss this

- The desire for companionship is not a spiritual weakness. God said "not good" before sin entered the world.
- Genesis 2 leads to marriage, but it does not teach that every person must marry. Jesus was not married.
- The seven motives are not a list of sins. The aim is to know the mixture, not to purify it.
- Contentment is the presence of trust, not the absence of desire. It is what makes it possible to say no.
- ʿēzer means help; that the woman is not made lesser is a fair conclusion from how Scripture uses the word, and should be taught as a conclusion.

Talk about it

1. Genesis 2 says "not good" before sin entered the world. What does that tell us about the desire for companionship?
2. Which of the seven motives do you think is most common in your church or community, and why?
3. Paul says he "learned" contentment. What helps a Christian learn it while still hoping to marry?
4. From the passage: Jesus was never married, and was fully human. What does that tell us about a whole life?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

Ask what they hope for, not when it will happen. A young adult who feels their desire is welcome at home is less likely to act on it in secret or in haste.

LESSON 2

What Does "Equally Yoked" Actually Mean?

Is "Are they a Christian?" enough?

At a glance	
Passage	2 Corinthians 6:14–7:1 (read: 6:14–16)
Also read	1 Corinthians 7:39 · Deuteronomy 22:10 · Matthew 7:16 · Galatians 5:22–23 · 1 Corinthians 7:12–14
The learner will see	What Paul meant in 2 Corinthians 6:14, in its setting in Corinth, and why "only in the Lord" applies it to marriage Why the label "Christian" is the beginning of the question, not the end Five questions underneath the label: conversion, fruit, doctrine, church and direction Four mistakes to avoid, including forgetting that the yoke has two sides
Reflection	Tool 2, Spiritual Compatibility Reflection (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If you feel pressured or unsafe in a relationship or a marriage, you do not have to stay alone with it. Please speak with someone you trust.

Purpose

To move learners beyond "Are they a Christian?" to the questions underneath the label, while teaching 2 Corinthians 6:14 honestly in its setting and reminding them that the yoke has two sides.

Scripture and background

Corinth was a Greek city full of temples and idol feasts. The passage is about idolatrous partnership and holiness (6:16; 7:1). Applying it to marriage is an inference; 1 Corinthians 7:39, "only in the Lord", states the principle directly.

The original word

ἑτεροζυγέω (*heterozygeō*) — "to be unequally yoked" (2 Corinthians 6:14), from heteros, "different", and zygos, "yoke". It occurs only here in the New Testament. Many commentators connect the image with Deuteronomy 22:10, the ox and the donkey.

The book's cautions

Christians differ in doctrine and church practice. Keep the "Christians differ" slide fair: share the centre, sort the differences honestly, and ask rather than assume. Never use the lesson to judge another person's heart.

Don't miss this

- 2 Corinthians 6:14 is first about idolatrous partnership in Corinth. Applying it to marriage is a reasonable inference; 1 Corinthians 7:39 ("only in the Lord") states the principle more directly.
- The label "Christian" is the beginning of the question. The five questions look for fruit over time; they never claim to judge a heart.
- Keep the Christians differ slide fair: share the centre, sort the differences honestly, and ask rather than assume.
- The yoke has two sides: every question applies to the learner as well.
- Anyone married to an unbeliever must not hear this lesson as permission to leave (1 Corinthians 7:12–14).

Talk about it

1. 2 Corinthians 6:14 was first written about life in a city full of idols. What changes, and what stays the same, when we apply it to marriage?

2. Of the five questions (conversion, fruit, doctrine, church, direction), which do you think Christians most often skip, and why?
3. What does it mean in practice that "the yoke has two sides"? Talk about the principle, not about any particular person.
4. From the passage: Paul says "only in the Lord" (1 Corinthians 7:39). Why do you think he gives so much freedom and only this one limit?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

Talk about what you see in a person's life, not only their church label. Be careful not to turn denominational loyalty into a test of faith.

LESSON 3

Know Yourself Before You Choose Someone Else

Who am I, and what do I really need?

At a glance	
Passage	Proverbs 4:23 (in its setting, Proverbs 4:20–27)
Also read	Lamentations 3:40 · Romans 12:3 · Romans 14:5 · Psalm 139:23–24 · 2 Corinthians 5:17
The learner will see	What it means to "keep your heart" (Proverbs 4:23), and why self-knowledge begins from being known by God Four reasons self-knowledge comes before choosing, including why it protects you Nine areas to understand about yourself, and how to look at your patterns Four kinds of requirement: foundational, personal non-negotiables, preferences, and protective rules to examine
Reflection	Tool 3, Personal Values and Non-Negotiables Sheet (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If looking back brings up harm you have experienced, or if you are afraid of someone you are dating, you do not have to carry it alone. Please speak with someone you trust.

Purpose

To help learners know themselves before they choose someone else: their needs, patterns and requirements, examined from the security of being known by God.

Scripture and background

Proverbs 4 is a father teaching his son: heart, mouth, eyes and feet (4:23–27). Biblical self-examination returns to God (Lamentations 3:40) and aims at sober, accurate judgement (Romans 12:3).

The original word

לֵב (*lēḇ*) — "heart" (Proverbs 4:23; in the verse, libbekā, "your heart"). In the Old Testament the heart is the centre of thinking, choosing and desiring, not only feeling.

The book's cautions

The book distinguishes foundational requirements, personal non-negotiables, preferences and protective rules. Protective rules may come from painful experience; examine what each protects, and do not dismiss a sound boundary simply because it began with pain.

Don't miss this

- In Hebrew the heart is the centre of thinking, choosing and desiring. Guarding it means watching where our choices begin.
- Self-examination begins from security in Christ, not anxiety, and it ends by returning to God (Lamentations 3:40).
- Self-knowledge is protective: a person who knows what they believe and will not accept is harder to define or control.
- Keep the four kinds of requirement apart. Violence, threats, coercion and control are never compatibility differences.
- Patterns are information, not condemnation. Never ask a group member to describe their own past relationships; offer private help.

Talk about it

1. Proverbs 4:23 calls the heart the source of life. Why might self-knowledge be a spiritual discipline, not only a practical one?
2. Of the nine areas, which do you think Christians most often leave unexamined before marriage, and why?
3. Why is the length of someone's list less important than understanding what each requirement means and why it matters? Talk about the principle, not about any particular person.
4. From the passage: Proverbs 4 speaks of heart, mouth, eyes and feet. Why might the order matter?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

Your son or daughter learned many of their patterns at home. Be willing to hear what they want to keep, and what they do not, without defending yourself.

PART 2 · CHOOSING WISELY

Part 2 trains the eyes: attraction and discernment, character, warning signs and the quiet green flags.

LESSON 4

Attraction Is Not Discernment

If I feel this strongly, doesn't it mean something?

At a glance	
Passage	Hebrews 5:14 (in its setting, 5:11–14)
Also read	Proverbs 31:30 · Proverbs 14:15 · 1 Samuel 16:6–7 · Philippians 1:9–11 · Song of Songs (delight without shame)
The learner will see	Why discernment is a trained capacity (Hebrews 5:14), not something that comes with a strong feeling What attraction is, what it can tell you, and what it cannot How attraction changes the way we interpret what we see, and why intensity is not meaning Five practical habits of discernment, from two columns to honest outside voices
Reflection	Tool 4, Chemistry vs Character Reflection (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If you are afraid of how someone will react, or a relationship is moving fast while you are being drawn away from others, you do not have to face it alone. Please speak with someone you trust.

Purpose

To honour attraction as a gift while showing that it is not a guide: discernment is trained by practice, and strong feeling is not the same as meaning.

Scripture and background

The readers of Hebrews had become "dull of hearing" and needed milk, not solid food. The verse is first about spiritual maturity in general; the lesson applies it to choosing a spouse, and says so.

The original word

γυμνάζω (*gymnazō*) — "to train, exercise" (Hebrews 5:14; in the verse, γεγυμνασμένα, "trained"), the word behind English "gymnasium". Discernment is built by practice over time.

The book's cautions

The book teaches that attraction and attachment can remain strong even when someone is harming you. Continuing to want a person does not make a relationship safe. The book advises against couples counselling as a first response to coercion.

Don't miss this

- Attraction is a gift, not a guide. It can open a door; it cannot tell you about character.
- Hebrews 5:14 describes discernment trained by practice. It is first about spiritual maturity in general; the lesson applies it to choosing a spouse.
- Attraction changes how we interpret what we see. The explaining is not stupidity; it is attraction doing what attraction does.
- Discernment uses time, ordinary life, two columns, honest questions and other people. No tests or traps.
- Continuing to want someone does not make a relationship safe. Never ask a group member to describe their own relationship; offer private help.

Talk about it

1. Why do you think Christians sometimes swing between treating attraction as everything and treating it with suspicion?
2. Hebrews 5:14 says discernment is trained by practice. What kinds of practice train discernment in ordinary Christian life?
3. Why might people who are not attracted to someone see them more clearly? Talk about the principle, not about any particular person.
4. From the passage: Samuel was sure when he saw Eliab (1 Samuel 16:6–7). What did God correct, and what did he not condemn?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

When your young adult is excited about someone, share their joy first. Questions asked later, gently, are heard; warnings given at the first mention are usually not.

LESSON 5

Character Before Charisma

How do I see who someone really is?

At a glance	
Passage	2 Samuel 15:1–6 (with 15:7–12 summarised)
Also read	Luke 16:10 · Matthew 7:15–20 · Titus 1:16 · James 1:19 · Proverbs 27:21 · Genesis 31:20
The learner will see	What Absalom at the city gate teaches about warmth used as a means of influence, without making charm itself a sin The difference between charisma (what a person can present) and character (what a person actually is) Nine windows into character, and how to look through them by watching, not testing Why integrity is the master window, and how your own bias can mislead you in either direction
Reflection	Tool 5, Character Observation Sheet (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If you have seen cruelty, intimidation or a pattern of deception, or you are afraid of disappointing someone, you do not need to keep observing. Please speak with someone you trust.

Purpose

To teach learners to tell charisma from character, and to look through the nine windows of character by watching over time, not by testing.

Scripture and background

Absalom stood at the city gate, warmly greeting all who came. After four years he had himself declared king at Hebron (15:7–12). His warmth was strategic. The story is not a profile of every charismatic person, and charm itself is not sinful.

The original word

גָּנַב (*gānaḇ*) … לֵב (*lēḇ*) — "stole the hearts" (2 Samuel 15:6): the verb "to steal" with the word for heart met in Lesson 3. The same idiom appears in Genesis 31:20 ("Jacob tricked Laban"). In this context it describes winning people by deception; the verb alone does not establish a special sense of manipulation.

The book's cautions

Many observations need context, but serious harm or danger can be decisive even the first time. In ordinary failures, the response and lasting change reveal character; some actions are serious enough that an apology does not make the relationship safe.

Don't miss this

- Charisma is what a person can present; character is what they are. Charm itself is not sinful.
- Absalom's warmth was a means of influence. The story is not a profile of every charismatic person.
- Character shows in small things (Luke 16:10). The nine windows are looked through by watching, not testing.
- Nobody passes every window. Watch the response to failure: repair is more revealing than the failure.
- If a window has shown cruelty, intimidation or fear, stop observing and get help. Never ask a group member to describe their own relationship; offer private help.

Talk about it

1. Why do you think churches so quickly reward visible gifts with visible roles? What could help?

2. Which of the nine windows do you think people most often overlook, and why?
3. Charisma is not a red flag, but it is not a green one. Which bias do you recognise more in yourself? Talk about yourself, not about any particular person.
4. From the passage: Absalom said, "Oh that I were judge in the land!" and promised justice to everyone who came (2 Samuel 15:4). How can words that sound caring serve someone's own aims?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

Notice character as well as achievements, and say what you see. "I noticed how kind they were to the waiter" is more useful than "they seem nice".

LESSON 6

Red Flags Christians Spiritualise

When is a spiritual explanation hiding a real warning?

At a glance	
Passage	Proverbs 22:3
Also read	Proverbs 1:4 · Proverbs 14:15 · 1 Thessalonians 5:21 · 1 John 4:1 · Acts 17:11 · 2 Timothy 4:14–15
The learner will see	What biblical prudence is: seeing danger and acting on it (Proverbs 22:3) Three categories: differences to talk about, patterns to watch, and danger that is serious the first time Seven patterns, and the spiritual language that can disguise them Five steps to take when you recognise a flag, and how to turn the list on yourself
Reflection	Tool 6, Red Flag Checklist (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If you are afraid of the person you are dating, or have been threatened, hurt, pressured or watched, go to the support page before anything else. Use a device they cannot access. If you are in immediate danger, contact the emergency service where you are.

Purpose

To show that biblical prudence sees danger and acts, and to help learners notice when spiritual language is hiding a real warning, without making them suspicious of ordinary imperfection.

Scripture and background

Proverbs was written "to give prudence to the simple" (1:4). "Simple" means inexperienced, not unintelligent: prudence can be learned.

The original word

עָרוּם (*ʿārûm*) — "prudent" (Proverbs 22:3): shrewd, sensible, one who sees ahead and acts. In Proverbs it is a virtue. The same word describes the serpent as "crafty" in Genesis 3:1; the word is about shrewdness, and context decides its use.

The book's cautions

Keep the three categories apart: differences to talk about, patterns to watch, and danger that is serious the first time. The full list of serious harm, digital-safety guidance and the note on threats of self-harm are on the lesson page and in the book; the book advises never confronting a dangerous person alone.

Don't miss this

- Prudence is a biblical virtue: seeing danger and acting on it. Testing what is said in God's name is obedience, not unbelief.
- Keep the three categories apart: differences to talk about, patterns to watch, and danger that is serious the first time.
- A red flag is not a flaw. Do not let the lesson make anyone suspicious of ordinary imperfection.
- Never ask a group member to describe their own relationship in detail. Discuss the teaching; offer private help.
- Forgiveness, grace and not judging are true teachings; the lesson corrects their distortion, not the teachings themselves.

Talk about it

1. Why do you think warning signs are easier to see in someone else's relationship than in our own?

2. Which of the five good teachings (forgiveness, not judging, not gossiping, suffering, grace) is most often misused in Christian circles? Talk about the teaching, not about any particular person.
3. Paul left Alexander's judgement to the Lord and still warned Timothy. What does that teach us about forgiveness and wisdom?
4. From the passage: Proverbs 22:3 says the prudent sees danger and hides himself. How is seeing real danger different from being suspicious of ordinary weakness?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

If you are worried about someone your young adult is dating, say what you have seen once, calmly, and keep the door open. Pressure and ultimatums usually push people closer to the person you fear.

LESSON 7

The Quiet Green Flags That Matter

What good signs should I actually look for?

At a glance	
Passage	Philippians 1:9–10 (in its setting, 1:3–11)
Also read	Ephesians 4:15, 25 · Proverbs 28:13 · James 1:22 · 1 Corinthians 13:4
The learner will see	Why Paul prays that love and discernment grow together (Philippians 1:9–10) Which encouraging signs are good but not enough by themselves Ten quiet green flags, and why the response to failure matters most What exclusivity is, and what to have seen before choosing it
Reflection	Tool 7, Questions Before Becoming Exclusive (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If there is abuse, intimidation, coercion or a credible concern for your safety, please do not move towards exclusivity. Seek individual support from someone trustworthy and independent.

Purpose

To teach learners to recognise the quiet green flags of a good relationship, and to make exclusivity a decision, not a drift.

Scripture and background

Paul writes from imprisonment to believers he loves; the letter would be read to the gathered church. The prayer is for a whole church, not a dating couple; the lesson says so before applying it.

The original word

δοκιμάζω (*dokimazō*) — "to test, examine, and so approve what proves genuine" (Philippians 1:10), used of testing metals and coins. "What is excellent" translates "the things that differ" or "the things that really matter".

The book's cautions

Serious abuse, intimidation or coercion is not an ordinary failure to be balanced against someone's green flags. Safety comes first. The absence of long friendships is not automatically a concern (moving country, ministry, disability, caregiving, betrayal, social anxiety).

Don't miss this

- Philippians 1:9–10 is a prayer for a whole church, not a dating couple: love and discernment grow together.
- Politeness, attendance, gestures, spiritual language, reputation and agreement are good but not enough alone.
- The ten green flags are relational and observable. The master green flag is words and behaviour that align.
- Nobody shows all ten all the time. Watch the response to failure.
- Exclusivity is a decision, not a drift. Never ask a group member to describe their own relationship; offer private help.

Talk about it

1. Why do you think quiet goodness is so easy to overlook, in dating and in church life?
2. Which of the "encouraging but not enough" signs do people most often over-count?
3. Which of the ten green flags is hardest for you to offer? Talk about yourself, not about any particular person.

4. From the passage: Paul prays that love will abound "with knowledge and all discernment". Why do love and discernment need each other?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

Tell your young adult when you see a good sign in someone they are dating. Encouragement that is specific helps them recognise what to value.

PART 3 · DATING WITH YOUR EYES OPEN

Part 3 covers the practical life of a dating relationship: boundaries, sexual holiness, family, money and the past.

LESSON 8

Boundaries Without Shame

Is it unloving to have limits?

At a glance	
Passage	Matthew 5:37 (in its setting, 5:33–37)
Also read	Luke 5:15–16 · Galatians 6:2, 5 · Proverbs 25:28 · Song of Songs 2:7 · Romans 8:1 · Psalm 16:6
The learner will see	What Jesus meant by a plain yes and no (Matthew 5:37), and how the lesson applies it The difference between a boundary, a request, an agreement and control Why boundaries are not shameful, and six kinds of boundary in dating How to set a boundary, and what to do when one is crossed
Reflection	Tool 8, Personal Boundaries and Dating Agreement (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If someone punishes, threatens, monitors or pressures you when you set a limit, you do not have to manage it alone. Please seek support from someone trustworthy and independent.

Purpose

To show that limits are not unloving: a boundary concerns my own choices, it can be set without shame, and it is different from control.

Scripture and background

Jesus is teaching on oaths and truthful speech. The verse is not first about dating; the application to a clear yes and no is named as an application. Jesus regularly withdrew from the crowds to pray: faithful love can include time away from other people's demands.

The original word

ναὶ ναί, οὒ οὔ (*nai nai, ou ou*) — literally "yes, yes; no, no" (Matthew 5:37): a plain yes and no with no oath added. In Galatians 6:2 and 6:5 Paul uses two different words ("burdens" and "load"); the lesson notes this without making the words carry more than the passage allows.

The book's cautions

Taking space because you need time or safety is not punishment; deliberately withholding contact or affection to make someone submit is manipulation. If speaking about a boundary could put someone at risk, they should not confront the person simply to complete a step; they should seek independent support.

Don't miss this

- Matthew 5:37 is about truthful speech; the lesson applies it, and says so.
- A boundary concerns your own choices. A request may be declined; an agreement is freely made; control removes freedom.
- Not a wall, a test, or a punishment. Boundaries run both ways.
- You can only give freely what you could have withheld.
- Coercion, intimidation or control is not a boundary conversation. Never ask a group member to describe their own relationship; offer private help.

Talk about it

1. Why do you think some Christians feel guilty about having limits?
2. What is the difference between a boundary and control? Give an example of each from ordinary life (not from anyone's relationship).
3. Which of the six kinds of boundary do people most often forget to draw?
4. From the passage: Jesus withdrew to pray while people still needed him (Luke 5:15–16). What does that free us to do?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

Respect the boundaries of an adult child as well. The way you receive their "no" teaches them what a safe "no" feels like.

LESSON 9

Sexual Boundaries, Practically

How do we honour God with our bodies before marriage?

At a glance	
Passage	1 Thessalonians 4:3–8
Also read	1 Corinthians 6:18–20 · Hebrews 13:4 · Romans 13:14 · Genesis 39:12 · 1 John 1:9
The learner will see	What Paul meant by sanctification (1 Thessalonians 4:3), and why holiness is first about belonging to God What Scripture says about sex and marriage, and what it does not say Why "just don't" is not enough, and how to "make no provision" with a plan in four parts What consent means, and what to do when the line is crossed
Reflection	Tool 9, Sexual Boundaries Plan (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If anything sexual happened to you without your consent, it was not your sin. If you are being pressured, threatened or harmed, or you are under eighteen and feel unsafe, please speak with someone safe and independent.

Purpose

To teach sexual holiness as belonging to God, without shame, and to help learners make a practical plan in advance rather than rely on willpower in the moment.

Scripture and background

Thessalonica was a young church, many of whom had "turned to God from idols" (1:9) and were learning a new way of life. Verse 6 shows that sexual sin can wrong another person; verse 8 says God gives his Holy Spirit, so holiness is not carried alone. The wording of verse 4 has been understood in more than one way; build no teaching on it.

The original word

ἁγιασμός (*hagiasmos*) — "sanctification" (1 Thessalonians 4:3): being made holy, set apart for God. Holiness is first about whom we belong to.

The book's cautions

If anything sexual happened to someone without their consent, it was not their sin. Scripture does not say sex is dirty, that worth depends on sexual history, or that one person is responsible for another's desire. For anyone under eighteen, follow your church's safeguarding policy.

Don't miss this

- Holiness is first about belonging to God; the body is not a problem to be managed.
- Scripture does not say sex is dirty, that worth depends on sexual history, or that one person is responsible for the other's desire.
- If anything happened without consent, it was not that person's sin.
- Wisdom in advance, not willpower in the moment: make no provision.
- Never ask anyone in a group about their own sexual history or relationship. Keep discussion general and modest; offer private help. For under-18s, follow your church's safeguarding policy.

Talk about it

1. Why is "just don't" not enough on its own?
2. What makes a plan drawn in advance easier to keep than a decision made in the moment?

3. How can a church speak about sexual holiness without heaping shame on people?
4. From the passage: Paul says God "gives his Holy Spirit to you" (verse 8). How does that change the way we think about holiness?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

Speak about sex with warmth and without panic. Make it clear that your love does not depend on their history, and that they can tell you if something was done to them.

LESSON 10

Family Patterns, Loyalties and Boundaries

How much does their family — and mine — matter?

At a glance	
Passage	Genesis 2:24
Also read	Exodus 20:12 with Ephesians 6:2 · Genesis 24:57–58 · Ruth 1:14, 16 · 1 Timothy 5:8 · Matthew 19:5
The learner will see	What "leave" and "hold fast" mean in Genesis 2:24, and how leaving differs between cultures What a family teaches, and the three questions that matter more than "Was it a good family?" How honour and responsibility to parents sit alongside a new household Five kinds of family objection, and why no family can consent for you
Reflection	Tool 10, Family Background Questions (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	No family can consent to a relationship for you, and none can force you into one. If you fear forced marriage, confinement, threats, or being taken abroad, do not start with a family meeting: contact a specialist service privately, using a safe device.

Purpose

To teach what "leave" and "hold fast" mean across cultures, to honour parents without obeying them as an adult, and to establish that no family can consent to a marriage for someone else.

Scripture and background

Genesis 2:24 is the narrator's "Therefore", drawn from creation before any human family tradition, and quoted by Jesus (Matthew 19:5). The stories of Rebekah and Ruth come from a very different social world and are not a modern courtship system.

The original word

עָזַב (*ʿāzaḇ*) · דָּבַק (*dāḇaq*) — "leave" and "hold fast" (Genesis 2:24). ʿāzaḇ: to leave, depart from; here, the forming of a new household and a change in first loyalty. dāḇaq: to cling, stay joined; the same verb is used in Ruth 1:14, "Ruth clung to her".

The book's cautions

The Family Background Questions are not a dossier on the other person's family. If forced marriage, confinement, threats or being taken abroad may be involved, never suggest a family meeting or mediation and never alert the relatives involved: offer private, specialist help.

Don't miss this

- Genesis 2:24 is about a change of first loyalty, not about distance; leaving looks different in different cultures.
- Not "Was it a good family?" but: what did they take, what did they reject, and what have they not looked at yet?
- Adult honour is real and lasting, but it is not obedience, unlimited access, financial compliance, or remaining exposed to abuse.
- Rebekah and Ruth are narratives from a different social world, not a courtship blueprint.
- Never ask a group member to describe their own family or relationship; keep discussion on principles. If forced marriage or honour-based abuse may be involved, do not suggest a family meeting or mediation: offer private help and follow your safeguarding procedures.

Talk about it

1. What does "leaving" look like in your culture, and what does honouring parents look like for an adult?
2. Why is "Was it a good family?" the wrong question?
3. How can a family objection be partly wise and partly prejudiced at the same time? (Talk about the principle, not about anyone's own family.)
4. From the passage: Ruth chose to cling to Naomi. How does her free choice shape what "holding fast" means?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

This lesson is especially for you. Your blessing, freely given, is a real gift; your permission cannot replace your adult child's own consent. Ask yourself which of your expectations are conscience, and which are preference.

LESSON 11

Money Reveals More Than a Salary

What does the way someone handles money show?

At a glance	
Passage	Luke 16:10–11
Also read	Matthew 6:21 · Mark 12:41–44 · Proverbs 22:7 · 2 Corinthians 9:7 · 1 Timothy 6:10 · Proverbs 30:8
The learner will see	What Jesus meant by "faithful in a very little" (Luke 16:10–11) Why income tells you less than the way money is handled, and six windows on character How money works between two people who are dating, and what to learn when The warning signs, and why scams and financial abuse are not warnings but harm
Reflection	Tool 11, Financial Warning Signs Checklist (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If someone you know only online asks you for money, do not send it. If someone is controlling your money, documents, work or studies, and you fear their reaction, get confidential advice before making changes they may notice.

Purpose

To show that the way someone handles money reveals character more than income does, and to separate ordinary concerns from exploitation such as scams and financial abuse.

Scripture and background

Luke 16 holds the parable of the dishonest manager, Jesus' words "You cannot serve God and money" (16:13), and the Pharisees, "lovers of money", who ridiculed him (16:14). Money is not a dirty subject, but it shows what we serve.

The original word

πιστός (*pistos*) — "faithful", trustworthy, reliable (Luke 16:10). "Entrust" in verse 11 comes from the same family of words: faithfulness and being trusted belong together.

The book's cautions

Dating is not a financial audit; honesty grows with the seriousness of the relationship. If someone known only online asks for money, the answer is not to send it. If someone is controlling a person's money, documents, work or studies, they should get confidential advice before making changes the other person may notice.

Don't miss this

- Not how much, but how: poverty is not a character flaw, and neither is wealth.
- Dating is not a financial audit; honesty grows with the seriousness of the relationship.
- Ordinary concerns deserve discernment; you are free to slow down or end a relationship. Exploitation (scams, financial abuse) calls for protection and help.
- As a dating safeguard: no co-signing, merged accounts, shared property or financial dependence.
- Never ask a group member about their own debts, income or relationship. Being deceived does not make someone foolish: treat anyone who has been scammed without shame.

Talk about it

1. Why does "What do they earn?" tell us less than we think?
2. Which of the six windows do people most often overlook?

3. Why do you think kind people are targeted by romance scams, and how can a church help without shaming them? (Talk about the principle, not about anyone's own finances.)
4. From the passage: The widow gave two small coins (Mark 12:41–44). What did Jesus see that others missed?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

Be careful not to judge a partner by income or family wealth. Do talk with your young adult about scams, debt and co-signing, as practical safeguards, without shame.

LESSON 12

Their Past Matters — But Not the Way You Think

How should I weigh someone's past, and my own?

At a glance	
Passage	1 Timothy 1:12–16
Also read	Psalm 103:10–12 · 2 Corinthians 5:17 · Acts 8:3 · Acts 9:26 · John 21:15–19
The learner will see	What Paul meant by "I received mercy" (1 Timothy 1:12–16) What the past cannot tell you, and the four questions it can answer What needs to be known, and when, and how to give and receive a disclosure Why neither record decides it, and why trauma is not a past to evaluate
Reflection	Tool 12, Past Relationship Reflection (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If something in someone's past, or in your own, involves violence, or a child or vulnerable person may be at risk, do not investigate or confront alone: seek specialist safeguarding advice. If something was done to you, it was not your fault, and you decide when to tell.

Purpose

To weigh the past with grace first: neither destiny nor irrelevant, with four questions that can be asked of it, and with trauma kept separate from things to be evaluated.

Scripture and background

Paul had been "ravaging the church" (Acts 8:3). After the Damascus road, the disciples in Jerusalem were at first afraid of him (Acts 9:26); trust was earned over time. Grace does not mean that every repentant person is suitable for every relationship.

The original word

ἠλεήθην (*ēleēthēn*) — "I received mercy" (1 Timothy 1:13, 16), from ἐλεέω, to show mercy. The verb is passive: mercy was done to Paul. He also writes "I am the foremost" in the present tense.

The book's cautions

Declining a relationship is not the same as denying forgiveness. Christians differ on remarriage after divorce: point people to their own church's teaching and their pastor. A history of violence, or any risk to a child or vulnerable person, is a safeguarding matter; do not investigate or confront alone.

Don't miss this

- The past is neither destiny nor irrelevant; grace first.
- Declining a relationship is not the same as denying forgiveness.
- Four questions: truth, responsibility, response, present effect. Trauma is not a past to evaluate.
- Christians differ on remarriage after divorce: point people to their church's teaching and their pastor.
- Never ask anyone in a group about their own past or anyone else's. A history of violence, or any risk to a child, is a safeguarding matter: follow your church's safeguarding procedures.

Talk about it

1. Why do Christians sometimes treat the past as destiny, and sometimes as irrelevant?
2. Why does "Declining a relationship is not the same as denying forgiveness" matter?
3. How can a church receive people with difficult pasts without either shaming them or ignoring real risks? (Talk about principles, never about anyone's own history.)

4. From the passage: The church in Jerusalem was slow to trust Saul. Was that a failure of grace, or wisdom?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

If your young adult tells you about their own past, or a partner's, receive it calmly. You do not need to decide everything at once, and you do not need to tell others.

PART 4 · DISCERNMENT

Part 4 is about weighing: claims of guidance, counsel, compatibility, and two good people who are wrong for each other.

LESSON 13

"God Told Me" and Other Hard Questions

How do I test what feels like God's leading?

At a glance	
Passage	1 Thessalonians 5:19–22
Also read	James 1:5 · Psalm 119:105 · Judges 6:36–40 · 1 Corinthians 14:29 · Colossians 3:15 · Deuteronomy 18:22
The learner will see	What Paul meant by "test everything; hold fast what is good" (1 Thessalonians 5:21) What Scripture says about guidance, and why choosing a spouse is not a treasure hunt Why "God told me" is a problem in dating, and eight tests for any claim What to make of peace, open doors and fleeces, and how to hold your own sense of leading
Reflection	Tool 13, Testing Spiritual Claims Worksheet (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	"God told me" must never be used to pressure anyone. If it is being used that way, see Lesson 6, and talk to someone outside the situation. If a church leader is applying the pressure, seek confidential help outside that leader's influence.

Purpose

To teach learners to test what feels like God's leading, so that "God told me" never becomes a way to pressure anyone or to close a conversation.

Scripture and background

The young church in Thessalonica was unsettled by claims attributed to Paul (2 Thessalonians 2:1–2). In Corinth, "let the others weigh what is said" (1 Corinthians 14:29). Testing is not a lack of faith; it is obedience.

The original word

δοκιμάζω (*dokimazō*) — "test" (1 Thessalonians 5:21): to examine, to determine whether something is genuine. The same word as Lesson 7. Metal testing is an illustration, not the definition.

The book's cautions

Treat Christian differences about how God speaks today fairly, and avoid church labels. No claim that God has spoken binds another person's conscience, and a no needs no competing revelation. If a church leader is applying pressure, the person should seek confidential help outside that leader's influence.

Don't miss this

- Test everything; hold fast what is good. Testing is obedience, not a lack of faith.
- No claim that God has spoken binds another person's conscience; a no needs no competing revelation.
- Gideon's fleece shows God's patience, not a method for choosing a spouse.
- Treat Christian differences about how God speaks today fairly; do not use church labels.
- If anyone, including a leader, uses "God told me" to pressure someone, offer private, independent help, and follow your church's safeguarding procedures.

Talk about it

1. Why is "God told me" so hard to argue with, and why is that a problem?

2. Which of the eight tests do you find most helpful, and why?
3. How can Christians who differ about how God speaks today still agree about testing? (Talk about principles, not about anyone's own relationship.)
4. From the passage: Gideon asked for a sign twice, and God was patient (Judges 6:36–40). Why is that not a method for choosing a spouse?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

If your young adult says God has told them something about a person, ask how they are testing it, kindly, without dismissing their faith. And never use "God told me" yourself to settle their choice.

LESSON 14

Who Should Have a Voice in Your Relationship?

Whose counsel should I seek, and how do I weigh it?

At a glance	
Passage	1 Kings 12:6–11 (with 12:4–5 and 12:13–16 told)
Also read	Proverbs 15:22 · Proverbs 27:6 · Proverbs 11:14 · Galatians 6:5 · Proverbs 12:15 · Job 42:7 · Proverbs 19:20
The learner will see	What Rehoboam's choice of counsellors teaches (1 Kings 12:6–11), and what "counsel" means in Proverbs 15:22 Why you need other voices, and what parents, pastors, friends, mentors and professionals each see How to choose your counsellors, seek counsel well, and weigh what you hear When counsel becomes control, and what to do with too many or too few voices
Reflection	Tool 14, Counsel Map (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	Counsel is good; control is not. If someone forbids or punishes you for seeking counsel, or a leader or family member is pressuring your decision, see Lesson 6, and talk to someone outside the situation. If you are afraid to tell anyone about your relationship, that fear is the most important thing to tell someone. If family pressure may amount to forced marriage, do not arrange family mediation; seek specialist help.

Purpose

To help learners build a circle of good counsel, weigh what they hear, and recognise when counsel becomes control.

Scripture and background

Rehoboam asked the older men who had served Solomon, who advised kindness, then followed the young men he had grown up with, who urged harshness. The kingdom divided (12:13–16). God was at work to fulfil his word (12:15), and Rehoboam remained responsible for his choice.

The original word

סוֹד (*sôḏ*) — "counsel" (Proverbs 15:22): confidential conversation, a close circle. Psalm 55:14 ("We used to take sweet counsel together") uses the same word of a friend who later betrayed the psalmist: closeness alone does not guarantee wise counsel.

The book's cautions

Pastoral office does not automatically confer expertise in trauma, abuse, addiction, mental health, finance or legal risk. Hebrews 13:17 does not authorise a leader to compel an adult to marry or to override consent. If family pressure may amount to forced marriage, do not arrange mediation; seek specialist help.

Don't miss this

- Counsel informs the decision; it does not make it. A voice is not a vote, and it is not a veto (Galatians 6:5).
- Rehoboam had counsel; he chose the voices that agreed with him.
- Sincere counsellors can be wrong (Job 42:7): weigh counsel; do not simply obey it.
- Never ask a group to weigh in on a member's own relationship; no public discussion of anyone's partner.
- If someone forbids or punishes counsel, or a leader or family pressures a decision, offer private, independent help, and follow your church's safeguarding procedures.

Talk about it

1. Why do people often ask only the voices that will agree with them?
2. What makes a person's counsel worth weighing, and what makes it controlling?
3. How can a church be a place of good counsel without becoming an audience or a court? (Talk about principles, not about anyone's own relationship.)
4. From the passage: Job's friends sat with him for seven days, and God still said they were wrong (Job 2:13; 42:7). What does that teach about weighing counsel?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

You are one voice, perhaps a very important one, but a voice is not a vote and it is not a veto. If you have a stake in the outcome, say so.

LESSON 15

Can We Build a Life Together?

Beyond faith, can our lives fit together?

At a glance	
Passage	Proverbs 24:3–4
Also read	Luke 14:28–30 (illustration) · Ecclesiastes 4:9–10 · Genesis 2:18 · Proverbs 24:27 · Proverbs 14:1
The learner will see	Why a shared faith is a foundation, not yet a house (Proverbs 24:3–4) Why compatibility is not sameness, and why handling difference matters most Seven areas to look at, and how to sort differences into three groups How to count the cost of a shared life before you build
Reflection	Tool 15, Life Compatibility Reflection (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	These conversations are for a relationship where both of you can speak freely. If you cannot say what you really think without fear, or a conversation about differences is used to pressure or punish you, stop: see Lesson 6, and talk to someone outside the relationship.

Purpose

To show that a shared faith is a foundation, not yet a house, and to help learners look at whether two lives can be built together, sorting their differences honestly.

Scripture and background

"House" in Proverbs means a household. Proverbs 24:27, a few verses on, gives the order of building: prepare your work outside, then build your house. These proverbs are not a modern marriage checklist; they give wisdom about building.

The original word

כְּנֶגְדּוֹ (*kenegdô*) — returning to Lesson 1: "fit for him", corresponding to him (Genesis 2:18). "A counterpart, not a copy" is a teaching paraphrase, and is presented as one.

The book's cautions

Luke 14:28 is about the cost of following Jesus; use it only as an illustration, and say so. These conversations are for a relationship where both people can speak freely; a conversation about differences must never become a means of pressure.

Don't miss this

- A shared faith is a foundation, not yet a house; compatibility is not sameness.
- The deeper compatibility is the ability to disagree and repair.
- Luke 14:28 is about the cost of following Jesus; use it only as an illustration, and say so.
- An incompatibility is not a failure of love; never shame someone for naming one.
- Do not ask group members to sort their own relationship's differences aloud.

Talk about it

1. Why do Christians sometimes treat a shared faith as if it settles every other question?
2. Which kinds of difference make a marriage richer, and which make it harder to build?
3. Why might "uncounted cost" be more dangerous than cost itself? (Talk about principles, not about anyone's own relationship.)

4. From the passage: Ecclesiastes says "two are better than one" because they can lift each other up. What has to be true for that to happen?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

Be honest about what has been hard in your own marriage, where it is wise to do so. Young adults learn more from repair they have seen than from advice they have heard.

LESSON 16

When Good Christians Are Wrong for Each Other

What if we are both good people, but this is not right?

At a glance	
Passage	Acts 15:36–41
Also read	1 Corinthians 7:39 · Psalm 139:23 · Colossians 4:10 · 2 Timothy 4:11 · Hebrews 10:24
The learner will see	What Paul and Barnabas's parting shows, and what it does not (Acts 15:36–41) Why good is not the same as right, and why you cannot marry from gratitude or pity What "wrong for each other" looks like, and what it is not The theology of a good ending, and what to do when only one of you sees it
Reflection	Tool 16, Good Person, Wrong Relationship Reflection (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	This lesson is for relationships without abuse or control. If fear, coercion or control is present, do not call it incompatibility: see Lesson 6, and talk to someone outside the relationship. If you have decided to end a relationship and fear the other person's reaction, do not announce it alone.

Purpose

To free learners from the belief that they must marry a good person who wants them: good is not the same as right, and a gentle, clear ending can be faithful.

Scripture and background

This is a ministry disagreement, not a romance. Mark had withdrawn in Pamphylia; Barnabas was his cousin (Colossians 4:10). Paul later speaks warmly of Mark (2 Timothy 4:11), but Scripture records no reconciliation between Paul and Barnabas.

The original word

παροξυσμός (*paroxysmos*) — "sharp disagreement" (Acts 15:39). Hebrews 10:24 uses the same word in a good sense, "stir up one another to love"; in Acts it describes a painful disagreement that ended in separation.

The book's cautions

Teach Acts 15 without taking sides. The lesson is for relationships without abuse or control: never let incompatibility language minimise fear, coercion or control.

Don't miss this

- Good is not the same as right; no one is obliged to marry from gratitude, pity or obligation.
- Teach Acts 15 without taking sides, as a ministry disagreement, and do not claim a recorded reconciliation between Paul and Barnabas.
- Do not let incompatibility language minimise fear, coercion or control (Lesson 6).
- Receive a no as final; never present someone's no as disobedience to God.
- Do not ask group members whether their own relationship is "wrong"; offer private conversation instead.

Talk about it

1. Why do Christians sometimes feel they must marry a good person who wants them?
2. How can someone tell ordinary doubt from a persistent reluctance worth examining?
3. What does a clear, gentle no look like, and why is it kinder than ambiguity? (Talk about principles, not about anyone's own relationship.)

4. From the passage: God used both Paul and Barnabas after they parted. What does that say about endings between good people?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

If your young adult ends a relationship with someone you liked, support the decision. A clear no now spares two people far more pain later.

PART 5 · CONTINUE, SLOW DOWN OR WALK AWAY

Part 5 is about deciding: continuing with wisdom, slowing down, ending well, and the fear of never finding anyone.

LESSON 17

When to Continue With Wisdom

How do I know this difficulty can be worked through?

At a glance	
Passage	Ephesians 4:1–3
Also read	Colossians 3:12–14 · 1 Corinthians 13:4–7 · Galatians 6:1–5 · Proverbs 27:5–6
The learner will see	What "bearing with one another in love" means, and what it does not (Ephesians 4:2) Why continuing should be a decision, not a drift Four kinds of difficulty, and what makes a difficulty workable How to continue well, and when continuing is the wrong decision
Reflection	Tool 17, Continue, Repair or Reconsider Worksheet (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	This lesson is for ordinary difficulties. If there is fear, coercion, controlling behaviour, intimidation or violence, do not call it "working on it": see Lesson 6, and talk to someone outside the relationship.

Purpose

To teach how to continue a relationship with wisdom: continuing is a decision, not a drift, and a workable difficulty is named, mutual and showing change.

Scripture and background

Paul is writing to churches of very different people learning to live as one body. "Bearing with one another" is Christian patience within the church, not a command to remain in every dating relationship.

The original word

ἀνέχομαι (*anechomai*) — "bear with" (Ephesians 4:2): to bear with or tolerate patiently. Colossians 3:13 uses the same verb.

The book's cautions

Repair assumes two people of goodwill. If there is fear, coercion, controlling behaviour, intimidation or violence, it must not be called "working on it". The worksheet supports judgement; it does not issue one.

Don't miss this

- Continuing is a decision, not a drift; a yes with nothing named is a postponement.
- "Bearing with one another" is Christian patience within the church, not a command to remain in every dating relationship.
- A workable difficulty is named, mutual and showing evidence of change; a worksheet supports judgement, it does not issue one.
- Never let "working on it" rename harm; repair assumes two people of goodwill.
- Do not ask group members to diagnose their own relationship's difficulties aloud.

Talk about it

1. Why do relationships so often drift rather than decide?

2. What is the difference between bearing with ordinary weakness and carrying another person's responsibilities?
3. Why might evidence of change matter more than a promise? (Talk about principles, not about anyone's own relationship.)
4. From the passage: Paul joins patience with "the bond of peace". What makes patience healthy rather than draining?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

When your young adult is working through a real difficulty, ask what they have named and what has changed, rather than asking whether the relationship is "still on".

LESSON 18

When to Slow Down

When is "not yet" the right answer?

At a glance	
Passage	Proverbs 19:2
Also read	Ecclesiastes 3:1 · Song of Songs 2:7 · James 5:12 · Proverbs 21:5
The learner will see	What Proverbs 19:2 says about desire, knowledge and haste What a wise "not yet" is: a reason, a shape and an end When slowing down is right, and when it is the wrong answer How to slow down well, and how to review honestly
Reflection	Tool 18, 90-Day Relationship Review (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	Slowing down is for relationships where both people can speak and act freely. If there is fear, coercion, controlling behaviour, intimidation or violence, do not slow down: see Lesson 6, and talk to someone outside the relationship.

Purpose

To teach a wise "not yet": a pause with a reason, a shape and an end, and to show when slowing down is right and when it is the wrong answer.

Scripture and background

The proverb is about life generally, not courtship, but the principle transfers. Song of Songs 2:7 is a refrain in a love poem, not a rule or a timetable.

The original word

חָטָא (*ḥāṭāʾ*) · חוֹטֵא (*ḥōṭēʾ*) — the verb can mean to miss, to go wrong, or to sin. Proverbs 19:2 uses the participle: whoever makes haste with his feet "misses his way", that is, goes wrong. "Missing a mark" is a broader illustration of the verb (Judges 20:16 uses it of slingers who could "not miss"), not an image present in this verse.

The book's cautions

Slowing down is never the answer to an unsafe relationship. Ninety days is a practical checkpoint, not a proven test: set the period to fit the concern. Continuing takes two freely given yeses; ending takes one no. At the review, each reflects separately first; a joint conversation is optional, only where it is safe, and is not required to make a decision about your own future.

Don't miss this

- A wise "not yet" has a reason, a shape and an end; without an end it quietly becomes "never".
- Slowing down is never the answer to an unsafe relationship.
- Song of Songs 2:7 is a refrain in a love poem, not a rule or a dating timetable.
- Ninety days is a practical checkpoint, not a proven test; set the period to fit the concern.
- Continuing takes two freely given yeses; ending takes one no. Do not ask group members to describe their own pauses aloud.

Talk about it

1. Why is "not yet" so easily misused?
2. What makes a pause a decision rather than a drift?

3. Why must continuing take two yeses, while ending takes only one no? (Talk about principles, not about anyone's own relationship.)
4. From the passage: Proverbs joins desire with knowledge. What is the difference between desire with knowledge and desire without it?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

Respect a "not yet" your young adult has chosen. If others are pressing for a date, help protect the pause.

LESSON 19

When to Walk Away

How do I end a relationship well, and before God?

At a glance	
Passage	Romans 12:17–18 · Psalm 34:18
Also read	Matthew 5:37 · Proverbs 12:19 · Psalm 147:3
The learner will see	What Romans 12:18 means by "so far as it depends on you" How to know it is time, and what an ending is not How to end a relationship well, and what to do if they will not accept it Why an ending where you are afraid needs different rules, and what comes after
Reflection	Tool 19, Should We Continue? Decision Worksheet (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If you are afraid of how they will react, make a plan with a specialist before you end it.

Purpose

To teach how to end a relationship honestly and kindly before God, and to make sure that anyone afraid of how the other person will react follows different, safer rules.

Scripture and background

Romans 12 describes the life of people who have received God's mercy; it is written to the churches in Rome, not about dating. Psalm 34 is a psalm of David. No word study is set for this lesson; the safety question comes first, on Slide 2.

The original word

There is no word study in this lesson. The safety question comes first, before any teaching.

The book's cautions

Where there are threats, no-contact does not need the other person's agreement, and a decision does not need to be repeated. If they will not accept an ending, it may be repeated once where it is safe; if there are threats, stalking or intimidation, do not engage further. Recovery after abuse is kept separate from ordinary reflection: the harm was not the survivor's fault.

Don't miss this

- The safety question comes first; the ordinary advice is not for anyone afraid of how the other person will react.
- "So far as it depends on you" does not mean every relationship must continue; an honest, kind ending can be the peaceable way.
- Clarity is kindness: ambiguity is a slow cruelty.
- A threat of self-harm is handed to people who can carry it; it is not a reason to resume the relationship.
- After an abusive relationship, never invite a survivor to examine their "part" in the abuse; and never ask group members to describe a current ending, or a frightening one, aloud.

Talk about it

1. Why are Christians so rarely taught how to end a relationship well?
2. Why is ambiguity "a slow cruelty"?
3. What is the difference between explaining a decision and attributing it to God? (Talk about principles, not about anyone's own relationship.)
4. From the passage: "So far as it depends on you" sets a limit on our responsibility. Why is that a mercy?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

If your young adult is ending a relationship and is afraid, help them contact a specialist service before anything else. Do not confront the other person yourself.

LESSON 20

When You're Afraid You'll Never Find Anyone Else

What if I never marry?

At a glance	
Passage	Psalm 13 (all six verses)
Also read	1 Corinthians 7:7–8 · Matthew 19:12 · Hebrews 13:5 · Romans 8:38–39 · Psalm 37:4 and Jeremiah 29:11 (named, to show what they do not promise)
The learner will see	How Psalm 13 moves from "How long?" to "But I have trusted" What the fear of never finding anyone does, and what it is made of What Scripture does, and does not, promise about marriage What to do with the fear, and how to build the life you have now
Reflection	Tool 20, Relationship Reality Check (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If this fear has become hopelessness, please speak with someone today.

Purpose

To take the fear of never finding anyone seriously, to separate what God has promised from what he has not, and to help learners build the life they have now.

Scripture and background

The heading reads "To the choirmaster. A Psalm of David." A personal lament was preserved among the songs of God's people; honest prayer is in the Bible because God can bear it.

The original word

חֶסֶד (*ḥesed*) — "steadfast love" (Psalm 13:5): God's faithful, enduring love, loyal love that keeps covenant.

The book's cautions

Do not offer "there's someone for everyone". Whether marriage comes or not, it does not determine God's goodness towards a person. If anyone speaks of hopelessness, follow the crisis guidance below; do not handle it as a discussion question.

Don't miss this

- Take the fear seriously; it is ordinary, not a spiritual failure.
- God has not promised a spouse; he has promised never to leave. Do not offer "there's someone for everyone".
- Psalm 37:4 and Jeremiah 29:11 are not guarantees about marriage.
- Singleness is not a waiting room, and a bad marriage is not a lesser version of a good one.
- If anyone speaks of hopelessness, follow the crisis guidance; do not handle it as a discussion question.

Talk about it

1. Why is the fear of never finding anyone so rarely taken seriously in church?
2. What is the difference between wanting marriage and believing God has promised it?
3. What could your church do to be a place where unmarried adults are known, not just present? (Talk about principles, not about anyone's own fears.)
4. From the passage: David moves from "How long?" to "But I have trusted" without his circumstances changing. What changed?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

Do not joke about the clock, grandchildren or "being left on the shelf". Help your young adult build a full life now, and let them know it is a life you honour.

THE CLOSING LESSON

The closing lesson draws the course together at the threshold of engagement.

LESSON 21

Before You Say Yes to Engagement

How do we know we are near the threshold?

At a glance	
Passage	Genesis 2:24
Also read	Malachi 2:14 · Luke 14:28–30 (illustration only) · Genesis 24:58 (with its setting) · Proverbs 19:2
The learner will see	Why Genesis 2:24 makes engagement a promise to enter a covenant What engagement is, and what is essential before it The signs that you may be near the threshold, and the pressures that push too early How to approach the decision, with the Questions Before Engagement
Reflection	Questions Before Engagement (done alone; private)
Safety note on the page	If saying "not yet" would bring threats, punishment, spiritual condemnation or family retaliation, do not complete the engagement questions together. Seek independent help first.

Purpose

To show what engagement is, a serious promise to enter a covenant, what is essential before it, and how to approach the decision freely, with the Questions Before Engagement.

Scripture and background

Genesis 2:24 describes leaving, holding fast and becoming one flesh; Malachi 2:14 supplies the explicit covenant language. Rebekah's "I will go" (Genesis 24:58) comes from a setting where the marriage was largely arranged; the question was whether she would go at once. It is not a modern courtship model.

The original word

There is no word study in this lesson. The lesson draws the whole course together.

The book's cautions

The five essentials are conditions, not a scorecard. A proposal, family expectations, wedding costs or church approval never oblige anyone to marry. Engagement is serious, and it can still be ended.

Don't miss this

- Engagement is a promise to enter a covenant: serious, and still breakable.
- The five essentials are conditions, not signs; if any is missing, engagement is not the next step.
- Luke 14:28–30 is about discipleship; use it only as an illustration.
- Never ask a couple to complete the Questions Before Engagement in front of the group, or jointly where anyone is afraid.
- A completion record never says "ready", "prepared" or "certified".

Talk about it

1. Why should a proposal never be the first time marriage is discussed?
2. Which pressure towards early engagement is strongest in your church or culture?

3. What does "two free and informed yeses" protect? (Talk about principles, not about anyone's own relationship.)
4. From the passage: Rebekah was asked, "Will you go with this man?" Even in a largely arranged setting, why did her own answer matter?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For parents and mentors

If your young adult is approaching engagement, the most loving thing you can say is that you will support a "not yet" as gladly as a "yes".

9. After the course

When a learner finishes Lesson 21, the course page records it simply: "You completed Before You Say Yes on" a date. There is no certificate, and the wording never says "ready", "prepared" or "certified". Please keep to that in anything you say or give.

The closing page, **My Next Faithful Step**, invites each learner to name one next step. For some it will be to continue dating with wisdom; for some, to slow down or end a relationship; for some, to rest in a single life they are building well; for a few, to approach engagement.

For those approaching engagement, the next course is *Talk Before You Marry* (coming soon). Until it is available, point couples to their pastor or to good premarital preparation in their own church.

A last word to leaders: thank you. Walking with people while they make one of the largest decisions of their lives is holy work. Be patient, keep people safe, and keep pointing them to the God who is faithful whether marriage comes or not.

Appendix A · A group agreement to read together

1. We talk about the teaching, not about anyone's own relationship, family or past.
2. Nobody has to share anything. "I'd rather not say" is always enough.
3. Our Reflections are private. We do not ask each other what we wrote.
4. We respect one another's privacy and do not repeat personal information outside the group. Our leaders will explain the limits of confidentiality, including safeguarding responsibilities and legal requirements. Because this is a group, absolute confidentiality cannot be guaranteed.
5. We do not give advice about each other's relationships, partners or families.
6. If anything in a lesson raises a concern for you, you can speak to the leader privately, or go straight to Finding Help Where You Live.
7. We pray for each other, and we keep each other's dignity.

Appendix B · Local help: complete this before the course begins

Required. Every church or group completes this table before the first session, and checks it again each year. Learners can also use the course's Finding Help Where You Live page.

Country or region	
Date these contacts were checked	
Checked by	

Who	Name and how to contact them
Emergency service	
Domestic abuse helpline	
Forced marriage or honour-based abuse service	
Sexual violence support	
Crisis line (hopelessness or thoughts of suicide)	
Counselling service	
Financial or debt advice; scam reporting	
Our church's safeguarding lead	
Independent safeguarding contact outside our church leadership (for concerns involving a pastor or leader)	
Pastor to contact	

Appendix C · Original words in the course

✱ *All entries were reviewed in October 2026 for spelling, transliteration and meaning in context, using established biblical-language usage and accessible lexical references, and found acceptable. Confirmation against printed editions of BDB, HALOT and BDAG, with editions and page references recorded, is still to be completed. Leaders should not add further claims about these words beyond the word cards.*

Lesson	Word	Meaning (as taught)	Passage
1	עֵזֶר כְּנֶגְדּוֹ (ʿēzer kenegdô) ✱	a helper fit for him	Genesis 2:18

2	ἑτεροζυγέω (heterozygeō) ✱	to be unequally yoked	2 Corinthians 6:14
3	לֵב (lēḇ) ✱	heart	Proverbs 4:23
4	γυμνάζω (gymnazō) ✱	to train, exercise	Hebrews 5:14
5	גָּנַב (gānaḇ) … לֵב (lēḇ) ✱	stole the hearts	2 Samuel 15:6
6	עָרוּם (ʿārûm) ✱	prudent	Proverbs 22:3
7	δοκιμάζω (dokimazō) ✱	to test and approve	Philippians 1:10
8	ναὶ ναί, οὒ οὔ (nai nai, ou ou) ✱	yes, yes; no, no	Matthew 5:37
9	ἁγιασμός (hagiasmos) ✱	sanctification	1 Thessalonians 4:3
10	עָזַב (ʿāzaḇ) · דָּבַק (dāḇaq) ✱	leave; hold fast	Genesis 2:24
11	πιστός (pistos) ✱	faithful	Luke 16:10
12	ἠλεήθην (ēleēthēn) ✱	I received mercy (form in the passage; dictionary headword ἐλεέω, eleeō, to show mercy)	1 Timothy 1:13, 16
13	δοκιμάζω (dokimazō) ✱	to test	1 Thessalonians 5:21
14	סוֹד (sôḏ) ✱	counsel	Proverbs 15:22
15	כְּנֶגְדּוֹ (kenegdô) ✱	corresponding to him	Genesis 2:18
16	παροξυσμός (paroxysmos) ✱	sharp disagreement	Acts 15:39
17	ἀνέχομαι (anechomai) ✱	to bear with	Ephesians 4:2
18	חָטָא (ḥāṭāʾ) · חוֹטֵא (ḥōṭēʾ) ✱	misses his way, goes wrong (the verb: to miss, to sin)	Proverbs 19:2
19	—	No word study	—
20	חֶסֶד (ḥesed) ✱	steadfast love	Psalm 13:5
21	—	No word study	—